Interview Guide: Pet Owner Interviews

For Part 2.3 – Audience research and personas

Use this guide for both of your interviews. It gives you the core questions, a space for one question of your own, and a notes sheet to print. Each interview takes 15–20 minutes.

Choosing who to interview

- Both people must own a dog, a cat, or both, and be 18 or over.
- Choose two people who are **different from each other**, for example one who already pays for pet care (grooming, day care, kennels) and one who never has. The differences give you your primary and secondary persona.
- Family members are fine. Students on this module are not :(
- In person or a video call both work. A text or email exchange does not count as an interview.

Before the interview

1. Give the person the **Participant Information and Consent Form**. Let them read it and ask questions.
2. Get the consent form signed **before** you start. No form, no interview.
3. Only record audio if they ticked "yes" to recording. Otherwise take handwritten or typed notes.
4. Write the participant code (P1 or P2), the date and the place at the top of your notes sheet. Use the code, not their name, in everything you write afterwards.

What to say at the start: "Thanks for doing this. I'm researching how people choose and use pet care, for a college project. There are no right or wrong answers. I'm interested in your own experiences. You can skip any question or stop at any time."

The questions - YOU MAY CHANGE

Ask the questions in order. The *italic* lines are follow-up prompts: use them if the answer is short. The grey line under each question tells you which persona heading it feeds into. Don't read that part out.

Warm-up and background `Demographics`

1 **Can you tell me a bit about yourself: roughly what age bracket you're in, where you live, and what you do for work?**

Age brackets: 18–24, 25–34, 35–44, 45–54, 55–64, 65+. Area: town or county is enough.

Demographics: age, location, occupation

2 **What does a normal working week look like for you? How many hours are you out of the house?**

Do you work from home on any days? Does anyone else live with you?

Demographics and behaviours: shows whether day care or pick-up would matter

You and your pets Behaviours

3 **Tell me about your pet or pets. What are they, how old, and how long have you had them?**

How did they come to you: a breeder, a rescue, a friend?

Behaviours: what pets they have

4 **Walk me through a typical day with your pet, from morning to night.**

Who walks, feeds and plays with them? What do you do together at weekends?

Behaviours: what they do with their pets

5 **How would you describe the role your pet plays in your life?**

Can you give me an example of a time that shows that?

Behaviours: the role pets play in their life

6 **Think about the last time you paid for any pet service: grooming, training, day care, kennels or a sitter. How did you find it, and how did you book it?**

Did you search online, ask someone, or see it on social media? Which app or site? Did you book online, by phone or in person?

Behaviours: how they find and book services (also useful for Part 4)

7 **Which social media apps do you use most, and do you follow any pet accounts or pet businesses?**

What kind of pet posts make you stop scrolling?

Behaviours: platforms and content they respond to (also useful for Part 4)

Difficulties and worries Pain points

8 **What's the hardest part of looking after your pet: grooming, training, or day-to-day care?**

Tell me about a specific time that was difficult. What did you do?

Pain points: grooming, training, care

9 **What do you do with your pet when you go away overnight or on holiday?**

How do you feel about leaving them? Has anything ever gone wrong?

Pain points: links to the Doggy Hotel

10 **Have you ever had a bad experience with a pet care business, or decided not to use one? What happened?**

What would have changed your mind?

Pain points: what stops them booking

11 **If you were choosing somewhere new to mind your pet, what would you need to see or know before you'd trust them?**

Prices? Photos of the place? Reviews? Being able to visit first?

Pain points: what the website needs to show

Your own question Client update card

12 **Write one question of your own that relates to your client update card, and ask it here.**

Example: if your card adds a puppy class, you might ask "When your pet was young, what help did you look for, if any?"

Write it on your notes sheet before the interview. Ask the same question in both interviews.

Closing

13 **Is there anything about owning a pet, or about pet care businesses, that I haven't asked but you think I should know?**

Then thank them, and remind them how to contact you if they change their mind about taking part.

Interviewing tips

Do

- Ask about what they **did**, not what they **would do**. "The last time you…" gets better answers than "Would you…".
- Let silences sit. People often add the most useful detail after a pause.
- Write down striking phrases **word for word**, in quotation marks.
- Ask "Why?" or "Can you give me an example?" when an answer is vague.

Don't

- Don't describe Furry Friends or try to sell it. You're researching their life, not testing an idea.
- Don't ask leading questions, such as "Wouldn't online booking be easier?"
- Don't fill in answers from your own pet experience.
- Don't ask for anything they've already said no to on the consent form.

After the interview

1. **Within 24 hours**, read through your notes and add anything you remember but didn't write down. Mark these additions clearly, for example in a different colour.
2. If you recorded audio, type a transcript extract of the most useful 3 >5 minutes. Then delete the recording, as promised on the consent form.
3. Keep your notes exactly as they were. Don't tidy or rewrite them. Original notes are your evidence.
4. Store the signed consent form somewhere safe until you submit it.

Interview notes sheet

Print one sheet per interview. Continue on extra pages if needed.

Code (P1 / P2)	Date	Place or call platform	Start time	End time

☐ Consent form signed before starting Audio recorded: ☐ Yes ☐ No

DEMOGRAPHICS (Q1–2)

BEHAVIOURS (Q3–7)

PAIN POINTS (Q8–11)

MY CLIENT UPDATE CARD QUESTION (Q12) – WRITE IT HERE BEFORE THE INTERVIEW

QUOTES, WORD FOR WORD